MEMORANDUM

To: Dr. Kristin Pickering, Dr. Mari Ramler, and Dr. Paulina Bounds
From: Nimotallahi Azeez
Date: November 24, 2025
Subject: Prospectus for Master's Portfolio

Introduction

The contents of this prospectus will provide an outline, detailed descriptions, and background information on the projects that I intend to complete for my Master's Portfolio in the Spring of 2026. First, I will introduce my client project, where I serve as a program assistant at Tennessee Tech University's Office of Intercultural Affairs. The department connects diverse student populations through leadership development, mentorship programs, and community engagement initiatives, with a mission to support first-year and international students by building community and strengthening community understanding. My role involves creating leadership presentations, coordinating mentorship activities, researching influential leaders, and connecting students with community service opportunities while ensuring culturally responsive and inclusive practices.

Next, I will describe my first digital artifact, a research paper written for PC 6050: Rhetorics of Stem Professions, in which I examine how communication training for healthcare providers can reduce technological access barriers in digital health systems. Using health communication scholarship and equity frameworks, my study explores how providers can better support rural, elderly, and low-income patients in navigating telehealth and digital health tools. It highlights the life-saving importance of communication in ensuring equitable healthcare access.

Finally, I will introduce my second digital artifact, which is a multimodal project based on a co-authored chapter I wrote for PC 5950, examining algorithmic bias in artificial intelligence and refusing AI for students. The project will be presented as either a PowerPoint presentation or an infographic series designed for educators, administrators, and students. It draws on Joy Buolamwini's concept of the "coded gaze" to argue that educators must teach AI literacy rather than refusing AI tools entirely, challenging recent scholars who advocate for AI refusal as resistance.

All my projects will be connected by themes of equity, access, and social justice, with a focus on ethical responsibility in technical communication. I hope to create a portfolio that showcases how technical communication can be used as a tool for empowerment, bridging gaps between people, cultures, and technologies across different communities and contexts.

Client Project

My client project is being completed at the Office of Intercultural Affairs under the supervision of Ms. Charria Campbell. This department supports students, particularly first-year and international students, by building community, strengthening intercultural understanding, and connecting students with mentors who guide them through academic and social transitions.

My project focuses on leadership development and community engagement. I have created and delivered a leadership presentation titled "The Values of Leadership Skills," which used interactive activities to help students identify the leadership values most important to them. Participants wrote values such as “honesty”, “empathy”, and “teamwork” on sticky notes and reflected on how these values shape mentorship and community involvement.

Building on this foundation, I plan to create additional presentations and activities centered on effective communication as a leadership tool, strategies for improving verbal and nonverbal communication, community engagement and service, and motivational messages with reflective discussion activities. I also did a presentation on the need for effective communication skills. I also assist the office by researching influential leaders, creating weekly motivational messages for student mentors and mentees, and reaching out to community organizations for volunteer opportunities. This project contributes to supporting student leadership growth, increasing engagement among diverse groups, and strengthening a sense of belonging within the Tech community while fostering meaningful connections between students and their broader community.

Research Questions:

- How do professional and technical communication practices prepare college students for leadership and community engagement, and what role does mentorship play in developing effective communicators?
- Is communication merely a tool for transmitting information, or does it carry deeper ethical, rhetorical, and social responsibilities that students must learn to communicate effectively and responsibly in professional and community contexts?

Literature Review

My client project focuses on the role of communication in leadership development and how mentorship structures support a diverse student populations in navigating college transitions. Research consistently shows that students develop leadership competencies most effectively through relational, experience-based learning that emphasizes reflection, identity awareness, and communication skill-building.

Komives et al.'s Leadership Identity Development Model demonstrates that leadership identity develops through social interaction, engagement, and meaningful mentorship. Students "learn who they are as leaders by interacting with others and reflecting on those interactions" (2013). Those who control how leadership is taught and mentored hold significant power over how student identity develops and what kinds of leaders emerge. This emphasis on interactive learning through "participation in and access to" mentorship opportunities suggests that effective leadership development requires not just presenting information but ensuring that all students, in particular, first-year and culturally diverse students, have access to meaningful guidance and community connection.

I believe that leadership development is not just a passive transfer of skills; it is an active process of identity formation, cultural navigation, and relationship-building. What gets emphasized in leadership programs, who gets access to mentorship, and whose voices are centered are often dictated by institutional priorities, reinforcing certain leadership styles while marginalizing others. According to Littlejohn and Foss, "communication is the primary process through which humans build shared meaning" (2021). So leadership programs are not just neutral skill-building spaces; they both empower and exclude students, depending on how communication is approached. This is why work to create inclusive mentorship programs and culturally responsive leadership training matters so much. It makes us think about the students we are missing, who benefit from the leadership models we are teaching, and what happens when diverse voices finally have access to development opportunities.

As I progressed through my client project, I learned about Astin's Theory of Student Involvement, which shows that students who actively participate in campus activities and mentorship programs experience higher levels of personal development and academic success (Astin, 1984). Through discussions with my supervisor, Ms. Charria Campbell, she noted that gaps in student engagement often exist because some students are first-generation, while others come from diverse racial and cultural backgrounds and may need additional support and someone to listen to them, particularly first-year and international students. From these conversations, I realized that communal differences and a lack of inclusive practices can leave these groups feeling isolated from the campus community. This insight highlighted the importance of intentional, culturally responsive programs. Recognizing this need, the mentor–mentee program at Tennessee Tech was created to provide these students with guidance and support. Astin emphasizes that student involvement requires an investment of both physical and psychological energy; it is not passive. Physical energy refers to students' active participation in meetings, workshops, mentoring relationships, and leadership opportunities, while psychological energy involves motivation, attention, confidence, and emotional engagement in the learning process.

Communication training plays a crucial role in ensuring that leadership development reaches all students, not just those already comfortable navigating campus culture. Through my internship with the Office of Intercultural Affairs, I created interactive presentations and reflective activities that give students access to tools they might not otherwise encounter, especially those unfamiliar with American academic and social norms. Without these culturally responsive programs, their potential as campus leaders and community members might never be fully realized. This particular project also aligns with the idea that mentorship coordinators should take an active role in shaping leadership opportunities by seeking out students who might otherwise be overlooked. Creating presentations and facilitating mentor connections allowed me to contribute to empowering student voices that may not have been centered otherwise.

Ethical responsibility is also a key aspect of my project. Technical communicators have a moral and professional duty to actively counterbalance traditional approaches by ensuring that diverse student voices are equally represented in leadership development opportunities. This principle guided my approach to creating inclusive programming, which emphasized accessibility, cultural responsiveness, and respect for the varied experiences students bring to campus. While interactive workshops provide spaces for diverse voices to be heard, they also raise questions about how leadership identity develops and how students carry these lessons forward. Ideally, students apply these experiences by engaging in campus organizations, mentoring peers, and integrating inclusive and ethical leadership practices into their academic and professional lives, extending the impact of the program beyond the workshops themselves.

During my presentation process, some of my participants hesitated not just because they were unsure about sharing personal leadership values, but because they were navigating cultural differences in how leadership is understood and expressed. In participating in these activities, they were exploring identity formation in a new cultural context, which is both empowering and vulnerable. Of course, I addressed these concerns by creating space for multiple perspectives and validating diverse approaches to leadership. Through reflective activities, participants could explore their own values without pressure to conform to a single leadership model. I believe this inclusivity helps create meaningful engagement. By developing responsive leadership programming, I believe I am actively participating in this model of student support, one that is ethical, community-driven, and responsive.

First Digital Artifact: "Bridging the Technological Access Gap: The Critical Role of Communication Training in Healthcare Delivery"

Abstract:

This paper examines how communication training for healthcare providers can reduce technological access barriers in digital health systems. While telehealth, patient portals, and digital health applications promise greater healthcare access, many patients, especially rural, elderly, and low-income populations, struggle to use these tools effectively. A decade into widespread digital health adoption, reconsideration of access barriers continues to provide insight into how technology has been implemented and, regrettably, how vulnerable patients have been marginalized. My analysis of recent health communication research suggests that responses to digital health inequities remain largely superficial, with inadequate provider training to support patients. Healthcare systems often prioritize technological implementation over ensuring patients can actually navigate these tools. While many organizations have introduced digital literacy resources under the umbrella of patient education initiatives, I argue that these programs function more as additional materials than systematic provider training in communication skills. Examining the rhetoric involved illustrates how many of these initiatives focus on technology adoption rates and efficiency gains rather than addressing the root causes of access barriers.

My paper highlights how technological and economic forces continue to shape healthcare delivery, requiring patients to navigate systems not designed with their needs in mind. Despite patient education initiatives, vulnerable populations still experience communication gaps, technological confusion, and limited access to care, exposing the disconnect between healthcare innovation promises and patients' lived realities. This paper explores patients' struggles with digital health access, ongoing challenges, and the effectiveness of current support efforts through a health communication lens. It also examines the provider communication training's role in healthcare equity, questioning whether current approaches offer real access or merely mask ongoing inequities.

Research Questions:

- How can communication training for healthcare providers address technological access barriers in digital health systems?
- What role does provider communication play in ensuring equitable healthcare delivery for rural, elderly, and low-income populations?

Literature Review

Digital health access remains a significant challenge in modern healthcare, drawing attention to issues of equity, communication barriers, and systemic exclusion. In this paper, I have explored these disparities through models of health communication theory and digital equity frameworks to better understand the lasting impact on vulnerable populations and healthcare systems.

Health communication theory, particularly Moorhead et al.'s work on digital health tools, explains how technological implementation without communication support disrupts patients' ability to access care and maintain health. Many patients continue to experience confusion, technological anxiety, and healthcare delays, struggling to navigate systems while living with urgent medical needs. Being unable to use digital health tools is not seen as a system design failure but rather as patient inadequacy. Their voices, carrying the harsh truths of technological exclusion, are systematically unheard. It is as health communication scholars note, preventing patients from expressing their communication needs would "expose the part played by" healthcare systems and technology companies in creating access barriers. This exposure poses a threat as it would challenge the authority of healthcare administrators, technology developers, and policymakers. It risks exposing their prioritization of efficiency and cost reduction over patient-centered communication. The testimony of struggling patients can challenge the structures of power and innovation narratives through their shared experiences. These patients may develop a form of collective advocacy and shared identity. This can challenge and disrupt the dominant narratives celebrating digital health transformation.

Wang et al.'s research on digital health divides discusses how technological barriers disrupt healthcare continuity, creating a clear division between those who can access digital tools and those who cannot, which is evident in vulnerable populations' ongoing struggles with telehealth and patient portals. This divide forces patients to choose between attempting unfamiliar technology or forgoing care entirely, dealing with systems that no longer align with their capabilities. I believe that digital health implementation is an example of how rapid technological change can leave patients trapped between promises of improved access and the reality of exclusion, confusion, and worsening health outcomes. While healthcare systems celebrate innovation and efficiency gains, patients struggling with technology remain invisible in conversations about healthcare progress. Their struggle to access care stems from issues such as inadequate provider communication training, technological design failures, and implementation strategies that prioritize institutional needs over patient communication support.

Pagano's concept of health communication as relational and contextual provides insight into why provider training matters for digital health equity. Communication is essential "for patient understanding" and successful healthcare delivery. In digital health systems, this reality is clearly evident. While healthcare has rapidly adopted technological tools, the communication training necessary to support patients has lagged far behind. Instead of fostering genuine access, technology implementation often creates new barriers while maintaining cycles of exclusion that prevent vulnerable populations from receiving the guidance they need. Despite initiatives such as patient education portals and digital literacy resources, research shows that many patients still cannot effectively use telehealth and digital health tools. I assert that these initiatives often serve as surface-level responses rather than addressing the core need for systematic provider communication training. My research builds on these ideas by examining how communication barriers continue to affect vulnerable patients and how provider training can contribute to lasting improvements in healthcare equity and access.

Second Digital Artifact: Digital Communication Project

Abstract:

This multimodal project examines algorithmic bias in artificial intelligence and argues for AI literacy education. Based on Joy Buolamwini's concept of the "coded gaze," I analyze how AI systems mirror and amplify social inequities through biased design, disproportionately harming marginalized communities in hiring, education, healthcare, and criminal justice. My analysis of recent research on AI in education reveals a troubling trend: some educators advocate for refusing generative AI in classrooms as resistance to technological exploitation. While concerns about linguistic justice and protecting student autonomy are valid, I argue that outright refusal is misguided and ultimately harmful. Refusing to teach AI literacy does not protect students; it leaves them unprepared to navigate a world already shaped by these systems.

My project highlights how algorithmic bias perpetuates systemic inequities and why educators have an ethical responsibility to teach collaboration and engagement rather than avoidance. Despite calls for AI refusal, students will encounter AI in their academic, professional, and civic lives. Without proper education, they remain vulnerable to manipulation and discrimination by systems they cannot recognize or challenge. This project explores AI literacy as empowerment, examining effective pedagogical approaches and questioning whether refusal offers real protection or merely masks ongoing educational inequity. This work will be presented as either a PowerPoint or a series of infographics and will target educators, administrators, and students, providing practical strategies for teaching and learning about AI in an ethical and critically informed manner.

The content draws on Joy Buolamwini's concept of the "coded gaze," the way artificial intelligence mirrors and amplifies social injustices through biased design and deployment. I maintain that educators must teach students to critically engage with AI rather than refuse it entirely. This position stands against the article GenAI Refusal of (Fernandes & McIntyre, 2025) that advocates for refusing Generative AI in classrooms as a form of resistance. Buolamwini's *Unmasking AI* offers a general discussion of algorithmic bias; however, in this project, I interpreted her ideas through the lens of education to explore their implications for students and learning environments.

Research Questions:

- How does algorithmic bias in AI systems perpetuate inequities, and what responsibility do educators have in teaching AI literacy?
- Should educators refuse or engage with generative AI in the classroom, and what are the implications of each approach for student empowerment?

Literature Review

This project builds on principles from Joy Buolamwini's work on algorithmic justice and the "coded gaze." Buolamwini emphasizes that understanding AI bias goes beyond recognizing technical errors, and "the coded gaze" is an effective framework to understand how AI systems reflect and amplify existing social inequities, making visible the often-invisible ways technology perpetuates discrimination (Buolamwini, 2023). This approach was essential for me in developing arguments about why AI literacy education matters for justice and equity.

According to Buolamwini, effective AI literacy education includes essential elements such as understanding how AI systems are built and by whom, recognizing patterns of bias in algorithmic outputs, and developing strategies for critically engaging with AI rather than passively accepting its results. The approach involves:

- **Understanding the Coded Gaze:** recognizing that AI systems reflect the biases, values, and blind spots of their creators and training data.
- **Identifying Real-World Harms:** examining concrete examples of how biased AI affects hiring, education, healthcare, and criminal justice.
- **Teaching Critical Engagement:** demonstrating how students can question AI outputs, recognize bias, and advocate for ethical technology.
- **Rejecting Digital Humiliation:** using Buolamwini's framework, we don't have to accept harm as the inevitable cost of innovation.
- **Empowering Through Education:** showing students that AI literacy is a form of justice work, giving them tools to challenge rather than be controlled by technology.

Throughout my project development, I applied these techniques by framing AI literacy education within a justice narrative that highlighted educators' ethical responsibilities. This approach allowed me to clearly define the problem of algorithmic bias, emphasize the importance of critical engagement over refusal, and demonstrate why AI literacy is essential for student empowerment. Instead of simply stating that educators should teach about AI, I framed the project around the real harms algorithmic bias causes in facial recognition, hiring algorithms, educational technologies, and more. This allowed me to make a convincing case for AI literacy as justice work, ensuring that audiences could see why collaboration rather than refusal better serves students navigating a world already shaped by these systems.

Conclusion

Throughout the progress of my master's portfolio, I, from the positionality of a technical communicator, have tried to explore the ways in which technical communication can serve as a tool for social justice, advocacy, and ethical responsibility. The projects that I have completed so far -the leadership development work with the Office of Intercultural Affairs, my research paper on healthcare communication and digital health, and my multimodal project on AI literacy and algorithmic justice- all demonstrate how communication can be used not just to document and analyze, but to empower, uplift, and create meaningful change. These works of mine align with the principles of advocacy and social justice by challenging existing power structures and amplifying the voices of underrepresented communities.

“If technical communicators choose not to consider social justice, they are working ineffectively. And unjustly. They are doing harm” (Walton et al., 2019, p.166). This quotation challenges the view of technical communication as neutral. It points out that technical communication is always influenced by existing power structures and is not simply about information transfer. A key takeaway is that ignoring equity, accessibility, and representation can actually reinforce oppressive systems. I believe this quotation also pushes us to consider the responsibility technical communicators have. We need to think critically about who benefits from our work and who might be excluded or even harmed. Failing to address social justice in technical communication is not just ineffective; it actively contributes to inequities in access, knowledge, and opportunity. So I think recognizing the role of social justice in this field means making sure our work is not just efficient, but fair and meaningful for the people it affects.

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Timeline of Completion

Client Project Proposal: 10-9-2025

Client Project Mid-Term Progress Report: 11-12-2025

Client Project: 12-8-2025

Final Recommendation Report: 12-8-2025

Research Report: 12-10-2025

Prospectus (2nd draft): 1-20-2026

Digital Artifact 1: 1-20-2026

Digital Artifact 2: 2-15-2026

Portfolio Revisions: 2-20-2026

Final Portfolio: 3-13-2026

Defense: Week of April 6th or the week of April 13th